SMALL BUSINESS BASICS · CANADA

Quotes That Get a Clear Yes

Write quotes and estimates customers understand, accept and can hold you to

A plain-language guide for Canadian small-business owners

First edition · November 2026

Quotes That Get a Clear Yes — Write quotes and estimates customers understand, accept and can hold you to

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Nothing in this guide is legal advice. Consumer protection rules on estimates, deposits and contracts vary by province, and GST/HST rules are set by the Canada Revenue Agency and can change.

No result is promised. How useful any idea in this guide turns out to be depends on your business, your customers, your market, and how you apply it.

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Before you start

What this guide covers and who it is for

A quote can be the first piece of paper a customer gets from you. It sets the price, but it also sets expectations: what you will do, what you will not do, when, and what happens if something changes. When those expectations are written down clearly, there is less room for an “I thought that was included” conversation at the end of a job.

This guide walks through quoting from the first phone call to a signed acceptance and the follow-up after. It covers quotes versus estimates, gathering details, writing scope, building a price, presenting options, GST/HST, deposits, change orders, basic terms, written acceptance, tracking quotes, and what to do when a customer says the price is too high.

It is written for Canadian trades and service businesses that price work job by job: painters, electricians, plumbers, renovators, landscapers, cleaners, movers, caterers, photographers, consultants and anyone else who sends a number before the work starts. The examples lean toward Nova Scotia, but the process works anywhere in Canada. Where rules vary by province, the guide says so and tells you where to check.

How to use it, and what it is not

Read the chapters in order the first time. Each ends with a short key points box. The *Templates and worksheets* chapter has a quote-prep worksheet, a quote layout, scope wording, an acceptance block, a change-order form, follow-up emails and a quote log to copy into your own documents or software. The one-page *Checklist* is meant to be printed. All businesses, names and numbers in the examples are made up.

This guide is general information. It is not legal, tax or accounting advice. An accepted quote can become part of a contract, and contract and consumer protection law is provincial and depends on your situation. Have a lawyer review your standard terms before you rely on them, and take GST/HST questions beyond the basics to an accountant or the Canada Revenue Agency (CRA).

Start right: the label and the details

Quote or estimate: what each word usually means

The words “quote” and “estimate” are sometimes used as if they meant the same thing. They can mean quite different things, and your customer may read them differently than you do.

- **Quote** (or fixed-price quote): a firm price for clearly described work. If the job is done as described, that is the price. If the work changes, the price changes through an agreed change order.
- **Estimate**: your best informed guess at the cost, based on what you know now. The final bill may be higher or lower once the work starts.
- **Quote with allowances or unit prices**: a firm price for the parts you can see, plus a set amount or per-unit rate for the parts you cannot. For example, a fixed price to replace a deck, plus a rate per joist for any rotten ones found underneath.

Why the wording matters

What counts is what the document says and what you and the customer agreed, not only the label at the top. Still, the word you choose shapes what the customer expects, and it can affect your obligations.

Some provinces have consumer protection rules that deal with estimates. These can include limits on how far a final price can go above an estimate without the customer’s consent, or requirements about what a written estimate or contract must contain. The rules differ by province and can depend on the type of work, whether the customer is a consumer or a business, and where the agreement was made (for example, at the customer’s door).

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Do not assume an “estimate” lets you charge whatever the job ends up costing. Check your province’s consumer protection rules, usually on your provincial government website, and ask a lawyer if the job is large or unusual.

Choose one approach per job and make the label and the wording match. If you can see and measure the whole job, a fixed-price quote is usually clearer for both sides. If there are real unknowns, such as old wiring behind walls or an event with no final guest count, say what is unknown, how you will price it, and how you will tell the customer before costs go up. If you give a ballpark on the phone, put it in writing that way: “This is a rough range only, not a quote. I can give you a firm price after a site visit.”

Gather the details before you price

A quote built on a five-minute phone call is a guess with a price on it. A disagreement at the end of a job can sometimes be traced back to something nobody asked about at the start: the second bathroom, the furniture that needed moving, the lane a truck could not get up.

For physical work, a site visit lets you see, measure and photograph what you are pricing. For consulting, design or event work, a discovery call does the same job. Decide in advance whether visits are free or carry a fee that is credited if the customer goes ahead, roughly how long you will spend, and who needs to be there (ideally the person who will sign).

Keep a standard list of questions so nothing is missed when the customer is talking quickly. Write the answers down as you go, in the customer's own words where you can:

1. What do you want done, in your own words? What does "finished" look like?
2. Is there a date it must be done by, or dates when work cannot happen?
3. Who else needs to approve this: a partner, landlord, condo board or manager? If it is a business, do you need a purchase order number on the quote?
4. Has other work been done on this before? Anything I should know?
5. Are there access issues: parking, stairs, pets, alarm codes, working hours?
6. Will you supply any materials yourself?
7. Do permits or inspections apply, and who will arrange them?
8. Do you have a budget range in mind? (Optional, but it helps you suggest the right option.)

> **TIP**
>
> Ask "What would make this job a disappointment for you?" The answer can tell you more about expectations than any measurement.

Some small jobs can be priced from photos or a short video the customer sends. That can save a trip, but say in the quote that the price is based on the photos provided and may change if conditions on site turn out to be different.

Photograph existing conditions, especially anything already damaged or unusual, and write down measurements, model numbers and what the customer tells you. Store it all with the quote. If someone later asks whether a crack in the tile was there before you started, you can check. Collect only the personal information you need for the job and keep it secure; privacy law applies to personal information you collect in business.

It is also reasonable to decline, or to ask for more information first, when the work is outside what you are qualified or licensed to do, when nobody can tell you what is wanted, or when design or permit work has to happen before anyone can price it. A polite "This is not a good fit for us, but here is who you might try" leaves the door open without committing you to a number you cannot stand behind.

Finally, tell the customer when to expect the quote, and send it by then. If you are waiting on supplier prices or a second opinion, say so and give a new date. A quote that arrives when promised starts the working relationship on a reliable footing.

KEY POINTS

- A quote usually means a firm price for defined work; an estimate is a best guess that can change.
- Some provinces have consumer protection rules about estimates. Check yours before relying on estimate wording.
- Ask questions and visit the site (or hold a discovery call) before you price.
- Photograph and measure existing conditions and store them with the quote.

Scope: inclusions, exclusions and assumptions

Describe the work in plain words

The scope is the part of the quote that says exactly what you will do. It is the part you and the customer will point back to if there is a disagreement, so write it so that someone who was not at the site visit could understand it.

- **Be specific.** “Paint walls and ceiling in living room (approx. 4.5 m × 5.5 m), two coats” rather than “paint living room.”
- **Be measurable.** Use quantities, sizes, counts and hours where you can.
- **Put it in order.** List the steps in the order they will happen.
- **Skip the jargon.** If you must use a trade term, explain it in a few words.

Inclusions, exclusions and assumptions

Inclusions are the items and tasks you are pricing. Spell out the ones a customer might not assume are part of the job: preparation (patching, sanding, protecting floors), the grade or brand of materials, clean-up and disposal, permits and inspections if you arrange them, and for service work, the number of revisions, visits or meetings.

Exclusions are things a customer might reasonably expect but that you are not doing or not pricing. Writing them down removes a lot of room for misunderstanding. For example:

- work on hidden conditions that turn out to be damaged
- moving large furniture or appliances
- trim, doors or closets, if not included
- electrical, plumbing or other work outside your trade or licence
- repairs to existing damage not listed in the scope
- permit fees, if the customer is arranging the permit
- defects in materials the customer chose to supply

> **TIP**
>
> After each site visit, ask yourself: “What will this customer be surprised I did not do?” Put those items in the exclusions.

Assumptions are the conditions your price depends on. If one turns out to be wrong, the price or schedule may change, and the quote should say how that will be handled. For example: “Work area will be clear and accessible on the start date.” “Existing walls are sound and need only minor

patching.” “Final guest count will be confirmed by [date].” “Customer will respond to design drafts within [number] business days.”

Allowances

An **allowance** is a set amount included in the price for something the customer has not chosen yet, such as light fixtures, tile or a vanity. If the customer picks something that costs more, they pay the difference; if it costs less, they get a credit. Say whether the allowance covers only the item or the item plus installation, and whether your markup applies to any difference.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you run a two-person renovation company in Kentville. Your bathroom quote includes “Allowance for vanity and countertop: $900.00 (supply only). If the selected vanity costs more or less, the difference will be added or credited on the final invoice.” The customer picks a $1,150.00 vanity. Because the allowance was in writing, the $250.00 difference is a simple line on the final invoice rather than a debate.

The same idea works when you truly cannot see part of the job. A plumber in Antigonish replacing a vanity can price the vanity, taps and supply lines firmly, then add: “If the drain inside the wall needs replacing, we will stop, show you, and give you a written price before doing that work.” The customer knows where the firm price ends and how the unknown part will be handled.

> **KEY POINTS**
>
> - Write scope that someone who was not at the site visit could understand.
> - List inclusions, especially prep, materials, clean-up and permits.
> - Take time on the exclusions list. It removes room for misunderstanding.
> - State your assumptions and what happens if they turn out to be wrong.
> - Use allowances for items the customer has not chosen yet.

Price the job

The building blocks

This chapter is about putting a price on a single job. Setting your hourly rate and your overall pricing approach is covered in more depth in the pricing guide in this series. Here, the goal is a price you can explain and defend, built from parts you can check:

- **Labour.** The hours the job will take, multiplied by what each hour costs you. For employees, that includes wages plus employer costs such as CPP and EI contributions. If you work alone, use the hourly amount you need to pay yourself.
- **Materials.** Everything you buy for the job: supplies, parts, rentals, disposal fees, delivery.
- **Markup on materials.** An amount added to the cost of materials to cover choosing, buying, picking up and handling them, plus returns, waste and price changes.
- **Overhead.** Business costs not tied to one job: vehicle, insurance, tools, phone, software, accounting. A simple way to include it is a set overhead amount per labour hour.
- **Contingency.** A cushion sized to the real risks of this kind of job, not added out of habit.
- **Profit.** What the business earns for doing the work, separate from what you pay yourself for your labour.

> NOTE
>
> Markup and margin are not the same. Markup is added to cost. Margin is the share of the final price that is profit. Mixing them up can lead you to underprice a job. The pricing guide in this series explains the difference with examples.

A worked example

Say you run Harbour Hues Painting, a two-person painting business in Truro, Nova Scotia. A homeowner wants the living room and hallway repainted: walls and ceilings, two coats, minor patching. You visit, measure and figure the job will take the two of you 14 hours each. These numbers are invented for the example; use your own costs.

Item	How it is worked out	Amount
Labour	28 hours × $45.00 per hour	$1,260.00
Materials	Paint, primer, filler, tape, plastic	$420.00
Markup on materials	15% of $420.00	$63.00
Overhead	28 hours × $12.00 per hour	$336.00
Contingency	4 extra labour hours × $45.00	$180.00
Cost before profit		**$2,259.00**
Profit	10% of $2,259.00	$225.90
Price	Rounded	**$2,485.00**

This is your internal worksheet. The customer does not need to see it. The quote they receive shows the description of work, the price of $2,485.00, the tax and the total.

Keep the worksheet with each quote. When the job is finished, compare the hours and materials you actually used against what you priced. Those comparisons are one of the most useful inputs you have for pricing the next job. The worksheet also tells you your floor: the lowest price at which the job still covers your costs and a fair profit.

Adding GST/HST if you are registered

If you are registered for GST/HST, you generally charge it on top of your price for taxable work. In the example the job is in Nova Scotia, where the HST rate at the time of writing is 14% (lowered from 15% on April 1, 2025).

Line	Amount
Price	$2,485.00
HST (14% HST, Nova Scotia)	$347.90
Total	**$2,832.90**

At the time of writing, GST is 5%. Ontario uses 13% HST; New Brunswick, Newfoundland and Labrador, and Prince Edward Island use 15% HST. Some other provinces charge a separate provincial sales tax. The rate you charge generally depends on where the supply is made, not where your business is located, so if you work across a provincial border, check CRA's place-of-supply guidance or ask an accountant. Confirm current rates on CRA's GST/HST rates page at canada.ca/revenue-agency before you set up your quotes.

If you are not registered, do not charge GST/HST or show it on your quote. You generally do not have to register while you are a small supplier: total taxable revenues of $30,000 or less over the last four consecutive calendar quarters and in any single calendar quarter. Once you pass that, there are rules about when you start charging tax and registering. Confirm the details at canada.ca/revenue-agency.

WATCH OUT

Charging GST/HST when you are not registered is not allowed. If a large quote could push you over the small supplier threshold, check CRA's guidance or talk to an accountant before you send it.

How much of the breakdown to show is up to you. Show enough that the customer can see what they are paying for and compare options. You do not have to show your hourly rate, markup or profit. If you do show a breakdown, make sure it adds up exactly. If you price by the unit (per square metre, per hour, per guest), show the unit rate and the quantity so the customer can see how the total was reached.

Many invoicing, accounting and field-service tools can build quotes from saved items and templates, collect an online acceptance and turn an accepted quote into an invoice. At the time of writing, examples include QuickBooks Online, Wave and Jobber. Features change, so check the current version of any tool before you rely on it. A word processor or spreadsheet template works too.

KEY POINTS

- Build each price from labour, materials, markup, overhead and contingency, then add profit.
- Keep an internal pricing worksheet with every quote, and compare it to actual results.
- If you are registered, show GST/HST on the quote and confirm the current rate with CRA.
- Do not charge GST/HST if you are not registered.

Present the quote clearly

What every quote should show

A clear quote is easier to say yes to and easier to hold each other to later. Whatever tool you use, include:

- your business name and contact details, and your GST/HST number if registered (for example, 123456789 RT0001)
- the customer's name and address, and the job site if different
- a quote number, the date issued, and a version number if you revise it ("Quote 2026-041, version 2")
- a short job title and the scope: inclusions, exclusions, assumptions and allowances
- the price, tax and total
- the start date or time frame, and roughly how long the work will take
- the deposit and payment schedule
- the date the quote is valid until
- your terms, or a clear reference to attached terms, and an acceptance block

Put the job title and total near the top, use clear headings (*Scope of work*, *Not included*, *Price*, *Payment*, *Acceptance*) and short bullet points, and attach standard terms on a separate page.

Offering options honestly

Offering two or three options (sometimes called good, better, best) can help a customer choose the level of work that fits their budget, and it turns the conversation from "yes or no" into "which one." To keep options honest:

- Make every option a real choice you would be happy to deliver. Do not add one that exists only to make another look better.
- Explain the differences in plain words: materials, durability, what is included, timing.
- Price each option fully, including tax, so totals can be compared.
- If you have a recommendation, give it and say why.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you run a landscaping business in Bridgewater. For a backyard refresh you offer **Option A**: clean-up, edging and mulch. **Option B**: everything in A plus new perennial beds along the fence. **Option C**: everything in B plus a small flagstone patio. Each has its own scope, price, tax and total, and the acceptance block asks the customer to tick one.

NOTE

The Competition Act prohibits false or misleading representations. A made-up “today only” price, or describing an option inaccurately, can create problems. If you are unsure, check guidance from the Competition Bureau Canada or ask a lawyer.

Validity, deposit and payment schedule

A validity period says how long you will hold the price. Write it as a date (“This quote is valid until December 4, 2026”) so nobody has to count, and say what happens after: “After this date, prices and availability will need to be confirmed.”

For small jobs, payment on completion may be enough. For larger jobs, or jobs where you buy materials up front, a deposit and staged payments can reduce the amount you have at risk. For each payment, state the amount, what triggers it (acceptance, a date, a stage of work), how the customer can pay (e-transfer, card, cheque) and when it is due. For example, on an $18,000.00 kitchen job (before tax): $3,000.00 on signed acceptance, $8,000.00 when the cabinets are installed, and $7,000.00 when the job is complete and you have done a walkthrough together.

WATCH OUT

Rules on deposits, contracts signed in the customer’s home and cancellation rights vary by province. Check your province’s consumer protection rules and have a lawyer review your deposit terms.

KEY POINTS

- Include scope, price, tax, dates, payment, validity, terms and an acceptance block.
- Lay the quote out so the total and scope are easy to find.
- Offer options only if each is a real choice, and explain the differences.
- Write the validity period as a date, and state each payment’s amount, trigger and due date.

Terms, change orders and acceptance

Standard terms: the basics

Your standard terms are the fine print that applies to every job. Write them once, carefully, and re-use them. Common topics:

- **Schedule.** How start dates are set, and what happens if weather, supply problems or the customer's own delays push them.
- **Cancellation.** What happens if the customer cancels after accepting, including whether any part of the deposit is kept to cover materials ordered or time already spent.
- **Changes.** That any change to scope will be priced and agreed in writing before the work is done.
- **Payment.** When invoices are due, accepted payment methods and any late-payment interest. Late fees or interest generally need to be agreed in advance, in the quote or terms the customer accepts, not added to an invoice afterwards. If you state interest as a monthly rate, also state the yearly rate, for example "2% per month (24% per year)". The federal Interest Act has rules on this; ask a lawyer how they apply to your terms.
- **Warranty.** What your workmanship warranty covers, for how long, and what it does not cover (misuse, normal wear, customer-supplied materials). Note that manufacturer warranties on products are passed on and handled by the manufacturer.
- **Site and access.** What the customer is responsible for: clear access, utilities, pets secured, decisions made on time.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Warranty and cancellation wording can have legal consequences, and consumer protection laws may give customers rights you cannot remove by contract. Have a lawyer review your standard terms before you use them.

Change orders

Jobs change. The customer adds a room, picks different materials, or you find rot behind a wall. A **change order** is a short written agreement that records the change, the price difference and any effect on the schedule, approved before the extra work is done. It should show the original quote number and a change-order number, a description of the change, the price increase or credit, the tax, the new contract total, any change to the completion date, and approval from both sides with the date.

Get the change approved before you do the work. A verbal "go ahead" on site is easy to remember differently later. If you cannot get a signature, a text or email reply saying "Approved, change order 3, $480.00 plus HST" is far better than nothing. Keep it with the job file, and keep blank forms in

the truck or on your phone.

Getting written acceptance

A clear yes in writing is the point of the whole process. It should be obvious which quote, which version and which option the customer accepted. Common ways to get it:

- **Signature on the quote.** Signed on site, or printed, signed and returned.
- **Electronic signature.** Many quoting tools let customers accept and sign online. Electronic signatures are generally recognized in Canada under federal and provincial electronic commerce laws, with exceptions for some kinds of documents.
- **Email reply.** A reply such as "I accept Quote 2026-041, version 2, Option B, total $2,832.90" can serve as written acceptance. Ask the customer to name the quote number and option rather than replying "sounds good."

Whichever method you use, the acceptance should refer to your terms, so the customer is agreeing to the terms as well as the price. The acceptance block in the templates chapter does this. If the job is large or unusual, or a lot of money changes hands up front, ask a lawyer whether a quote with an acceptance block is enough or whether you need a fuller written contract.

Keep every quote, version, acceptance, change order, email and photo together for each job; they are part of your business records. CRA generally requires you to keep books and records for six years from the end of the last tax year they relate to, and electronic records are acceptable if they are readable and available on request. Confirm the current rules at canada.ca/revenue-agency.

KEY POINTS

- Write your standard terms once, carefully, and have a lawyer review them.
- Agree any late-payment interest in advance, and state a monthly rate as a yearly rate too.
- Get every change approved in writing before doing the work.
- Make it obvious which quote, version and option the customer accepted, and keep it with your records.

Follow up, track and handle push-back

Following up without pressure

A customer may be busy, comparing quotes, waiting for a pay cheque or talking it over with someone. A follow-up gives them an easy way to ask questions or say yes. Here is a simple rhythm you could use:

1. **When you send the quote:** a short note with the total, the validity date and how to accept.
2. **A few days later:** a check-in asking if they have questions.
3. **Shortly before it expires:** a reminder of the date, with an offer to adjust the scope.
4. **After it expires:** one friendly note that leaves the door open, then stop.

Keep each message short and do not invent urgency. If the customer says no, thank them, ask once and lightly whether anything would have made the quote work better, and let it go.

Tracking your quotes

Once you send more than a handful of quotes, it is easy to lose track. A spreadsheet, a notebook page or your software's quote list can all work. Track at least:

Quote #	Customer and job	Sent / expires	Status
2026-041	Morrison, living room paint	Nov 4 / Dec 4	Accepted
2026-042	Cole, deck stain	Nov 6 / Dec 6	Follow up Nov 10
2026-043	Lee, exterior trim	Nov 7 / Dec 7	Declined (timing)

Add columns as needed: total, follow-up dates, reason won or lost, how the customer found you. When a quote is declined, note why if you know: price, timing, scope, chose someone else, project cancelled. Looking back over your own log every few months can show which kinds of jobs you tend to win, where your quoting time is best spent, and whether a pricing or wording problem keeps coming up.

When a customer says it is too expensive

"That's more than I expected" is information, not the end of the conversation. Stay calm and curious, and start by asking: "Is it more than your budget, or more than another quote you received?"

If it is over their budget, offer to change the scope rather than cut the price for the same work. Lowering the price for identical work can suggest your first number was padded. Instead, look for scope you can remove or phase: do the most important part now and the rest later, use a different

grade of material, have the customer do some prep themselves (with clear wording about what that means for your warranty), or point them to a lower option.

If they have another quote, ask politely whether it includes the same scope. Two quotes for the same job may not cover the same work. Walk them through what is in yours: prep, materials, clean-up, warranty, insurance. Never criticize the other business. If the scope truly is the same and their price is lower, it is fine to say you cannot match it.

If you made a mistake, say so and issue a corrected quote with a new version number.

Know your floor. Your internal pricing worksheet tells you the lowest price at which the job still covers your costs and a fair profit. Below that number, walking away is a reasonable business decision.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you run a cleaning business in Dartmouth and quote a move-out clean at $480.00 plus HST. The customer says it is too much. You ask, and learn they only need the kitchen and bathrooms done because they are cleaning the rest themselves. You send version 2 with a smaller scope and a lower price. The price changed because the work changed.

> **KEY POINTS**
>
> - Follow up on a simple, polite schedule, and stop after the quote expires.
> - Keep a quote log with numbers, dates, status and reasons.
> - When the price is too high, ask why, then adjust scope rather than cutting price for the same work.
> - Know your lowest acceptable price before you negotiate.

Templates and worksheets

Copy these into your word processor, spreadsheet or quoting software and replace anything in [square brackets]. Have a lawyer review any wording you rely on as part of your terms.

Quote-prep worksheet

WORKSHEET

Customer, contact and job site: _____

What they want and what "finished" looks like: _____

Deadline, dates to avoid, who approves: _____

Access, utilities, permits, customer-supplied materials: _____

Unknowns that could change the price: _____

Price build	Amount
Labour: _____ hours × $_____ per hour	$_____
Materials	$_____
Markup on materials	$_____
Overhead	$_____
Contingency	$_____
Cost before profit	$_____
Profit	$_____
Price before tax	$_____
Lowest price I would accept for this scope	$_____

Quote layout

TEMPLATE

[Your business name] · [Address] · [Phone] · [Email]

GST/HST number: [123456789 RT0001, if registered]

QUOTE [number], version [number] · Issued: [Date] · Valid until: [Date]

Prepared for: [Customer name], [Address] · **Job site:** [Address]

Job: [Short title, e.g., Repaint living room and hallway]

Scope of work: [Step or item, with quantities and materials] · [Next step] · [Clean-up and disposal]

Not included: [Exclusion] · [Exclusion]

Assumptions: [Assumption] · [Assumption]

Price before tax: $[amount] · **[GST/HST at rate]:** $[amount] · **Total:** $[amount]

Schedule: Start on or about [Date], approximately [number] working days.

Payment: Deposit of $[amount] on acceptance; balance of $[amount] plus tax due [when], by [methods].

Terms: This quote is subject to the attached Standard Terms, version [date].

Scope and exclusion wording

TEMPLATE

Hidden conditions: “This price is based on what we could see on [Date]. If we find hidden damage or conditions that need extra work, we will stop, show you and give you a written change order first.”

Customer-supplied materials: “We are not responsible for the quality, quantity, timing or defects of materials you supply. Extra time they cause will be charged at $[rate] per hour.”

Allowance: “This quote includes a $[amount] allowance for [item], supply only. Any difference will be added to or credited on the final invoice.”

Acceptance block

TEMPLATE

I accept Quote [number], version [number], [Option ___], for a total of $[amount] including [GST/HST]. I have read and agree to the scope, exclusions, assumptions, payment schedule and the attached Standard Terms.

Customer name and signature: _____ Date: _____

Business signature: _____ Date: _____

You can also accept by replying to the email this quote came with: "I accept Quote [number], version [number], Option [___]."

Change-order form

TEMPLATE

CHANGE ORDER [number] · Original quote: [number], version [number] · Customer: [Name]

Item	Detail
Description and reason for change	_____
Price change before tax (add / credit)	$_____
Tax on the change	$_____
Previous contract total	$_____
New contract total	$_____
Change to completion date	None / New date: _____

This change order forms part of the original quote and terms. Work on it starts once both parties have approved it.

Customer signature: _____ Date: _____

Business signature: _____ Date: _____

Follow-up emails

TEMPLATE

Subject: Your quote for [job] from [Business name]

Hi [Customer name], thanks for having me out on [Date]. Your quote for [job] is attached. The total is $[amount] including [GST/HST], and it is valid until [Date]. To accept, sign the last page or reply “I accept Quote [number].” If you have questions or want to adjust anything, reply or call [phone]. Thanks, [Your name]

Subject: Any questions about your [job] quote?

Hi [Customer name], I wanted to check whether you had questions about the quote I sent on [Date]. I am happy to walk through it or adjust the scope if something does not quite fit. Thanks, [Your name]

Subject: Your [job] quote is valid until [Date]

Hi [Customer name], a quick note that your quote for [job] is valid until [Date]. After that I would need to confirm prices and scheduling again. If the timing or budget is not right just now, I can look at a smaller scope or a later start. Thanks, [Your name]

Quote log

WORKSHEET

Quote # and total	Customer and job	Key dates	Status and reason
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____

Checklist

CHECKLIST

- [ ] Decided: fixed-price quote, estimate, or quote with allowances
- [ ] Checked my province’s consumer protection rules on estimates, deposits and contracts
- [ ] Visited the site or held a discovery call, using my question list
- [ ] Confirmed who approves and signs, and any purchase order number needed
- [ ] Photographed and measured existing conditions and saved them with the job
- [ ] Wrote the scope in plain words, with quantities and materials
- [ ] Listed inclusions, exclusions, assumptions and allowances
- [ ] Built the price from labour, materials, markup, overhead, contingency and profit
- [ ] Saved my pricing worksheet and know my lowest acceptable price
- [ ] Added GST/HST only if registered, at the current rate confirmed with CRA, with my GST/HST number
- [ ] Added a quote number, version, date issued and “valid until” date
- [ ] Stated each payment’s amount, trigger and due date
- [ ] Attached standard terms that a lawyer has reviewed
- [ ] Stated any late-payment interest as a yearly rate as well as a monthly rate
- [ ] Included an acceptance block naming the quote, version, option and terms
- [ ] Checked the quote for errors: totals, tax, dates and the customer’s name
- [ ] Sent the quote when I said I would, with a short covering email
- [ ] Logged the quote and set follow-up reminders
- [ ] Got written approval for every change order before doing the work
- [ ] Filed the acceptance, change orders, emails and photos with my business records
- [ ] Recorded why the quote was won or lost

Where to learn more

These are official sources and the kinds of professionals who can help. Organizations reorganize their websites from time to time, so start from the homepage and search if a page has moved.

- **Canada Revenue Agency** (canada.ca/revenue-agency): GST/HST rates, registration and small supplier rules, place-of-supply guidance, and keeping business records.
- **Competition Bureau Canada** (competition-bureau.canada.ca): guidance on false or misleading representations.
- **Your provincial government website** (in Nova Scotia, novascotia.ca): consumer protection rules, including any rules on estimates, deposits, contracts signed at home and cancellation rights. Search for "consumer protection".
- **Your province's small claims court website**: how the process works and the limit in your province, if a payment dispute cannot be settled.
- **Your provincial or municipal building office**: permit and inspection requirements for your work.

When the stakes are real, talk to a professional who knows your situation:

- **A lawyer** can review your standard terms, warranty and cancellation wording, deposit terms and acceptance process, and explain how your province's consumer protection rules apply to your quotes.
- **An accountant or bookkeeper** can help with GST/HST registration, which rate to charge across provincial borders, and a pricing worksheet that reflects your real costs.
- **Your insurance broker** can tell you what your coverage expects you to have in writing with customers.

Other guides in this series pick up where this one stops. The pricing guide goes deeper into hourly rates, markup and margin. The invoicing guide covers turning an accepted quote into a clear invoice and getting paid on time. The GST/HST guide covers registration, charging tax and filing returns.